a FlexLifeFi K–12 program

GRADE 7 · TEACHER GUIDE

How to Run This Year

Routines, pacing, FAQ, and the calibration of Cash's voice.

Year theme: Know Your Customer

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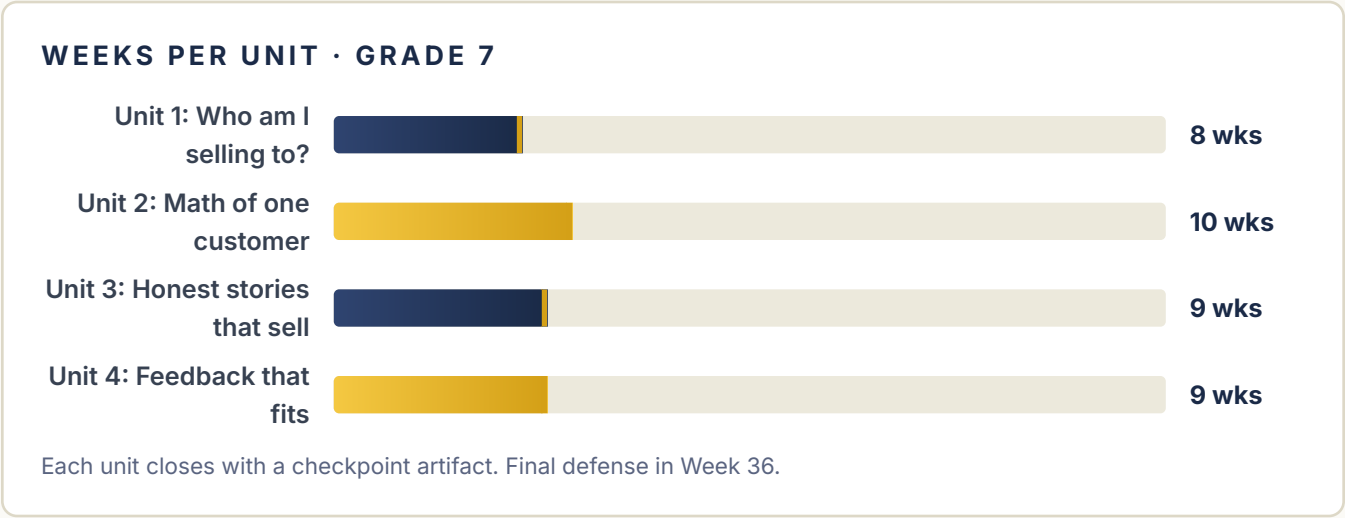
YEAR-AT-A-GLANCE

Four Units. Thirty-Six Weeks. One Capstone.

The year is built as four units, each ending with a public-facing artifact that feeds the rolling Capstone. The bars show how the weeks are spent — roughly equal, with a slight lean toward the math-heavy unit because per-customer math is the load-bearing skill.



36 WEEKS

4 UNITS

10 LESSONS

8 CASH VIDEOS

GRADE 7 · TEACHER GUIDE

How to Run This Year

Customers are evidence, not assumptions.

For: middle-school classroom teachers (typically ELA, social studies, business/CTE, or a dedicated entrepreneurship period), homeschool parents teaching the curriculum, and after-school program leads. **Companion to:** Grade 7 Curriculum Book, Lesson Plans, Student Activity Book, Cash Video Scripts, and Parent Guide.

How this year is built (and why)

"You don't have to know everything. You have to know one number."

— CASH

Grade 7 of Cash to Company is built around one concrete thing: a customer-first venture each student or pair carries from September to June. The year teaches four moves on that venture — find your customer, do the per-customer math, write honest messaging, install a feedback loop — and each move is anchored in evidence, not opinion.

The pedagogical bones come from three traditions:

- **Understanding by Design.** Big ideas, essential questions, and a year-end performance task drive the planning. Lessons feed the Capstone, not the other way around.
- **Workshop model.** Mini-lesson (10–15 min) → guided work (20–30 min) → confer + close (10 min). Students do most of their thinking on their own work most days.
- **Routines, not heroics.** The classroom runs on a small set of weekly routines — a Monday opener, a Wednesday work block, a Friday share-out — so that the cognitive heavy-lifting goes to the content, not the structure.

Classroom routines

These run all year. Establish them in the first three weeks and protect them.

Monday — Cash + the Question

A 5-minute Cash video (or printed transcript if no projector) introduces the week's question. Students respond to a one-prompt opener in the Capstone Journal. Whole-class share-out: 2–3 students.

Wednesday — Work Block

The longest block of the week, 45–60 minutes, dedicated to the Capstone. Mini-lesson (10–15) → independent or pair work (30–40) → 5-minute close. Teacher confers with 4–6 students per block in 3-minute one-on-ones.

Friday — Showcase + Stuck

15–20-minute share. Three or four students share progress; one student shares "where I'm stuck." Class generates suggestions using the "What's working / What's confusing / One change I'd try" frame.

Daily — the Vocabulary Spine

A single-page running glossary at the back of the notebook. Students add 1–3 terms per week with a Frayer entry for "weight-bearing" terms. Tuesday/Thursday have 5-minute vocabulary openers.

Pedagogy at this grade band

- **Concrete, then abstract.** Even at 7th grade, students benefit from running the math on real (or carefully simulated) numbers before they generalize. Use real local prices.
- **Talk before write.** Most students at 12–13 know more than they can put on paper at first try. Pair-share before journal write.
- **Identity-aware.** A 7th grader is figuring out who they are in public. Let them choose Capstones that signal something true to them — but coach against ventures that exclude classmates.
- **Visible thinking.** The Vocabulary Spine, Capstone Journal, and pinned-to-wall persona posters make student thinking observable. That's a CASEL win as much as it is a learning-design one.
- **Less worksheet, more artifact.** A persona poster, a one-page pricing memo, and a feedback dashboard are the year's products. Worksheets serve practice; they're not the goal.

Assessment philosophy

"Listening is not a moment. It's a system."

— CASH

Assess two things at every checkpoint:

1. **Did the student do the work the standard names?** Real interviews, real math, real test, real survey — not pretend versions.
2. **Did they think about it?** A "what I got wrong on the first try" line in every checkpoint memo. Reflection is a learning goal, not garnish.

Use the program's analytic rubrics (Rubric Bank) for the Capstone checkpoints. Use simple holistic checks (3-2-1, exit tickets, thumbs-up) during weekly work. Avoid the trap of grading effort or neatness — read for evidence of the standard.

A typical assessment cadence

Cadence	Form	Stakes
Daily	Exit ticket or work-block confer	Low — formative
Weekly	Capstone Journal entry	Low–medium — counts toward habit grade
Bi-weekly	Vocabulary check (10 terms)	Low — formative
End of unit	Capstone checkpoint with rubric	Medium-high — rubric-graded
End of year	Final Capstone defense	Highest — full-year synthesis

Pacing — week by week

The pacing below is a default. Adjust to your actual calendar (assume ~36 weeks). Each week needs roughly 90–120 instructional minutes for Cash to Company; the Capstone Journal homework is 10–15 minutes of writing.

Unit 1 — Who am I selling to? (Weeks 1–8)

Week	Focus	Anchor activities	Capstone milestone
1	Course launch + Cash V1 ("Customers are evidence")	Set norms; pick Capstone categories; write a "Day 1 customer assumption"	Choose Capstone category
2	Pick the Capstone	"Skills + Hobbies + Needs I See" web (Grade-3 strand recycled at higher complexity)	Lock Capstone topic + tentative customer
3	Demographic vs. behavioral	Two-column sort; mini-debate	Fill out Persona v1 (assumptions only)
4		Role-play interview practice in pairs	

Week	Focus	Anchor activities	Capstone milestone
	Interviewing — open vs. leading questions		Write a 7-question interview script
5	Conduct interviews (3)	Out-of-class interviews + classroom debrief	Submit 3 interview transcripts
6	Coding patterns	Highlight + tally on transcripts; "what surprised me"	Code transcripts
7	Persona v2 (evidence-based)	Build the persona poster	Persona v2 draft
8	**Checkpoint 1** — Persona pack	Gallery walk + peer feedback	Submit Persona Pack (graded)

Unit 2 — Math of one customer (Weeks 9–18)

Week	Focus	Anchor activities	Capstone milestone
9	Cash V2 ("Per-customer math runs the business") + optional pivot window	Pivot decision (kept or new venture)	Confirm Capstone or pivot
10	Revenue per customer	Build a revenue table	List products/prices
11	Variable cost per customer	Cost-of-goods analysis	Compute COGS per unit
12	Fixed cost vs. variable cost	Sort game; matching	Identify fixed costs
13	Contribution margin	"What's left to pay the rent?" framing	Compute contribution margin
14	Pricing tradeoffs	Three-price scenario	Test 3 prices in the model
15	Breakeven (intro)	"How many do I need to sell?"	Compute breakeven volume
16	Pricing memo writing	Mini-lesson on memo form	Draft pricing recommendation
17	Peer review	Critique frame	Revise pricing memo
18	**Checkpoint 2** — Pricing pack	Three-minute price defenses	Submit Pricing Pack (graded)

Unit 3 — Honest stories that sell (Weeks 19–28)

Week	Focus	Anchor activities	Capstone milestone
19	Cash V3 ("Honest claims build long-term customers") + optional pivot window	Two-page case: clever claim that backfired	Confirm Capstone
20	Persuasion techniques	Ad analysis; vocab bingo	Spot 5 techniques in real ads
21	Persuasion vs. manipulation	Borderline cases	Write your line
22	The 4-point Fair-to-Customer Check	Apply to a real product page	Apply to your Capstone
23	Writing a clear claim	Mini-lesson on specificity	Draft headline + 3 lines
24	Designing two messages	Choose two angles to test	Build A and B
25	Run the test	3-day in-class poster test (or digital)	Run the test
26	Reading the data	Lower-bar stats (counts, simple percentages)	Tally results
27	Memo writing	Mini-lesson + draft	Draft messaging memo
28	**Checkpoint 3** — Messaging pack	Pitch-back + peer panel	Submit Messaging Pack (graded)

Unit 4 — Feedback that fits (Weeks 29–36)

Week	Focus	Anchor activities	Capstone milestone
29	Cash V4 ("Feedback is a system, not a moment") + optional pivot	Discussion of "what does listening look like in a business?"	Confirm Capstone
30	Survey design	Open vs. closed; clarity; bias	Draft 3-question survey
31	Channel + cadence	Where + when to ask	Plan the system
32	Run the system	1-week feedback collection	Collect data

Week	Focus	Anchor activities	Capstone milestone
33	Signal vs. noise	Deciding what to act on	Triage the inputs
34	Iteration	Make 3 changes	Update product/ messaging
35	Capstone defense prep	Storyboard the defense	Build defense slides/poster
36	**Final Capstone Defense**	Public presentation	Deliver the defense

FAQ

Q: I have ELA, not business background. Can I teach this? A: Yes. The lesson plans script the moves; the Cash videos introduce concepts; you become the chief evidence-norm-enforcer ("which people, and how do you know?"). The financial math in Grade 7 is 7th-grade math: percentages, simple arithmetic, basic proportion.

Q: We don't have a class store or classroom economy. Can students still do this? A: Yes. Many ventures don't require currency exchange — content, services, events, repair, tutoring. For ventures that do require sales, simulated transactions are fine for the Capstone.

Q: My students can't go interview people outside class. A: Build a "customer pool" inside school: another grade level, school staff, after-school program kids. Or run interviews via classroom video calls (with permissions) with parents/community members. The skill is in the listening, not in who's listened to.

Q: A student wants to do a venture that feels off (gambling-like, weight-loss, exclusionary). A: Use the optional pivot windows. Coach early ("What about this idea is sitting wrong with me as the teacher? Let's talk it through."). Provide an alternative they'd find interesting. The Ethics, Safety, and Legal strand exists precisely for this.

Q: Some of my students don't have stable internet at home. A: Run the curriculum print-first. The Cash videos have transcripts; the persona, math, and feedback templates are 1-pagers; the Capstone Journal is a notebook, not an app. The optional digital extensions are explicitly optional.

Q: How do I assess fairly when students choose different ventures? A: The rubrics are content-agnostic. They measure persona quality, contribution-margin reasoning, claim integrity, and feedback-system rigor — not how cool the business is. A tutoring service and a snack venture can both score 4s if the work is rigorous.

Q: What if a student wants to talk about real family money problems triggered by these lessons? A: Refer to the school counselor. Don't try to handle it inside the lesson. The curriculum is designed to leave private home finance off the table; if a student volunteers something heavy, listen briefly, validate, and route appropriately.

Q: Do I need to give grades on the Cash videos? A: No. The Cash videos are concept anchors. Use them for opening discussions and reflection prompts. The Capstone checkpoints carry the grade weight.

Q: What's the minimum I can do if I'm out of time some weeks? A: Protect Wednesday's Work Block. Skip Monday or Friday before you skip Wednesday. The Capstone is the spine; everything else is helpful but not load-bearing.

Common pitfalls

"Don't sell. Show."

— CASH

- **The interview that wasn't.** A student writes "everyone said they'd buy it." Push back: which everyone? What did they actually say, in their own words? Require quotes in transcripts.
- **The fake variable cost.** A student claims their per-unit cost is $0.05 because they "got the supplies free." Coach: the cost of materials is the cost of materials, regardless of who paid. Practice "what would it cost to scale?"
- **The messaging that wasn't tested.** A student claims A worked better, but the test was 4 people. The rubric explicitly rewards small-but-real over big-but-fake.
- **The pivot that wasn't.** A pivot window doesn't mean "switch because your first idea was hard." It means "switch because evidence said the customer wasn't there." Make students articulate the evidence.
- **The defense that's a sales pitch.** The final defense is reflective: what I learned about my customer, my math, my message, my feedback. Not a Shark Tank cosplay. Coach toward evidence and revision, not enthusiasm.

Working with the Cash mascot

Cash is a mascot, not a teacher. Do not let students treat Cash's word as authority — Cash poses questions; students answer them in evidence. If a student says "Cash said do X," redirect: "What does your evidence say?"

For voice and personality of Cash, see the Cash Mascot Style Guide. Bottom line: Cash is curious and warm but does not flatter, does not promise quick wins, and never says "everyone can be rich." See style guide for forbidden phrases.

Working with parents and caregivers

The Parent Guide is sent home in Week 1 with a brief overview and three optional conversation starters. The biggest parent question is: "is my kid going to be asked to invest real money?" Answer: no. Capstones are educational; any real-money decisions are family decisions and outside the curriculum.

A teacher self-check at end of year

> *"Most adults skip this. You won't."*
>
> — CASH

Did most of my students this year:

- Talk to a real customer at least three times? (Yes/No)
- Compute and revise a contribution margin from real numbers? (Yes/No)
- Write a claim they could actually defend? (Yes/No)
- Make at least one product/messaging change because of customer evidence? (Yes/No)

If three of those four are yes, the year worked. If fewer, look at which routine slipped — usually the Wednesday Work Block.

Senior expert upgrade pack — Tightening (Grade 7 already near ceiling)

Quick adds

- **Multi-team comparison move.** Halfway through Unit 2, pair two Capstone teams and have each team review the other's contribution-margin worksheet. Surface: "What did you compute differently? Why?" Builds calibration.
- **Persona stress test.** At the end of Unit 1, advanced students "stress test" their persona by imagining the persona's worst day. "What does Marcus do when he's tired? When he's broke? When his Tuesday gets canceled?" The persona that holds up under stress is the one to trust.

- **The "Day 1 returns" move.** When you hand back the Day 1 Customer Assumption cards in Week 8 (Lesson 4), don't just have students compare to their persona — have them rate themselves on a 1-5 scale of "how wrong was I?" and circle the specific assumption that broke first. The dated-evidence-of-thinking-changing is the year's emotional payoff. Don't soften the discomfort.

ROUND 2 PATCH — Cash Never Says (Teacher Reference Card)

Cash never says: "Amazing!" / "Awesome!" / "Crushing it!" / "Boss up" / "Get that bag" / "Everyone can be rich" / "Easy money" / "Passive income" / "Financial freedom" / "Just believe" / "If you can dream it, you can do it" / "Side hustle" (use "side venture") / wealth-flexing language / anything implying wealth is mindset/hustle / anything implying low-income or unbanked families are at fault.

Cash always asks: "Which people, and how do you know?" / "What did they actually say?" / "Whats the evidence?" / "What would have to be true for you to be right/wrong?" / "Whats one thing youd change?"

Teacher mirror: Replace "great job!" with "okay, thats specific — whats the evidence?"

Cashs three signature physical moves: (1) **Notebook Tilt**; (2) **Two-Finger Tap**; (3) **Slow Lean**.

ABOUT THE HOST

Cash, in five words

curious · warm · honest · patient · specific

"I'm Cash. I don't promise wealth. I don't promise success. I promise that the moves — interview, math, message, listen — will make you a clearer thinker about money no matter what you end up doing."

— CASH

What Cash does

- **Asks questions that point to evidence.** Cash never tells; Cash asks what your evidence says.
- **Names rules sparingly.** "An assumption is something you think is true without checking. Evidence is something you observed, heard, or counted."
- **Tells short, made-up-but-realistic stories.** 30–60 seconds, shows don't tell.
- **Celebrates the move, not the win.** Revision, honesty, and evidence — not revenue.
- **Hedges deliberately.** probably, often, sometimes — never absolutes about complex topics.

What Cash never does

- Flatter ("amazing!", "great job!"), promise wealth, moralize about money.
- Reference real brands or living celebrities as endorsements.
- Surface family financial details. (Hypothetical scenarios only.)
- Pretend the world is fair. Cash is honest about systemic factors without becoming a politics class.

> *When in doubt, work one of these into the script: Which people, and how do you know? · Being wrong on Day 1 is the deal. · Revenue is loud. Contribution margin is true. · A little less wrong, every week.*

STRAND OUTCOMES

Eight Strands. One Year. Verifiable Outcomes.

Cash to Company runs the same eight strands K-12. Each year deepens the demonstration. The Grade 7 version of each strand is below.

Code	Strand	Grade 7 demonstrated outcome
BAVC	Business Awareness and Value Creation	Identify a business problem, propose a value-creation hypothesis, and revise it with customer evidence.
PSIG	Problem Solving and Idea Generation	Generate, screen, and refine ideas; document why one was chosen and the others were not.
MFL	Money and Financial Literacy	Compute revenue, variable cost, contribution margin, and breakeven for a real product or service.
CBM	Customers, Branding, Marketing	Build a persona from interview evidence; design honest messaging; A/B test two claims.
OSO	Operations, Systems, Organization	Design a simple weekly operating cadence with named roles, handoffs, and a feedback loop.
LTO	Leadership, Teamwork, Ownership	Run and document a team meeting; resolve one disagreement using shared evidence.
ESL	Ethics, Safety, Legal Awareness	Identify the line between persuasion and manipulation; flag one borderline claim and rewrite it honestly.
LRCI	Launch Readiness and Continuous Improvement	Pilot, measure, and document at least three iterations with rationale and what changed.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

Six Benchmarks This Year

Standards are cited at the benchmark level. Honest gaps are named when they exist. The Capstone artifact addresses each one.

Benchmark	What students must demonstrate
Jump$tart 6 (Financial Decision Making) 8-2	Identify ways consumers may avoid making poor decisions; apply to entrepreneurs avoiding poor customer guesses.
CCSS-ELA W.7.4	Produce clear and coherent writing in which the development, organization, and style are appropriate to task.
CCSS-ELA SL.7.1	Engage effectively in a range of collaborative discussions.
CASEL Social Awareness	Recognize the perspectives of others; demonstrate empathy.
C3 D2.Eco.1.6-8	Explain how economic decisions affect well-being of individuals, businesses, society.
Jump$tart 1 (Spending & Saving) 8-2	Demonstrate ability to use number skills to manage money.

HOW TO READ THIS TABLE

Each lesson cites at least one of these benchmarks. Each Capstone checkpoint addresses two or more. The Teacher Guide includes a per-lesson standards crosswalk.

"Standards aren't a cage. They're a list of moves you're going to be glad you can make. Pick one. Practice it. Move on."

— CASH

CAPSTONE RUBRIC (4-POINT)

How We Score the Capstone

The Capstone artifact is scored on four traits, each on a 4-point scale. Honest, specific, decision-oriented work earns the high marks. Generic or assumption-laden work earns the low ones.

Trait	1 — Emerging	2 — Developing	3 — Proficient	4 — Advanced
Evidence quality	Mostly assumptions; few or no quotes.	2-3 interview quotes; partial evidence.	5+ direct quotes; varied sources; coded patterns.	Triangulated quotes plus behavioral observation; counter-evidence acknowledged.
Per-customer math	Confused costs; no contribution margin.	CM computed but with errors; one price scenario.	Correct CM and breakeven; clear pricing rationale.	CM under multiple price scenarios; LTV-lite reasoning.
Honest messaging	Vague or misleading claims.	Some specifics; some unsupported claims.	All claims supported; clean ethics check.	A/B-tested copy with rationale; resists clever-but-borderline phrasing.
Feedback system	One-time check; no documentation.	Ad-hoc feedback; partial revisions.	1-week feedback loop with 3 documented changes.	Sustained loop plus signal-vs-noise analysis plus revision log.

CALIBRATION NOTE

Score honestly. A "3" means the student met the standard the way an adult professional would. A "4" means they did something a working entrepreneur would be proud to show. Withhold "4" unless the work earns it.

SENSITIVITY AND FAMILY ENGAGEMENT

What We Don't Ask. What We Always Frame.

Money is a tool, not a virtue. Some students live in households with credit-card debt, low or no banking access, or active financial stress. The curriculum is built so that none of those students is asked to disclose, perform, or apologize for their family situation.

Rules of the room

- **Never ask about family money.** No questions about parents income, debts, accounts, or banking status.
- **Use neutral hypotheticals.** "For a sample family with a $4,000/month take-home" — not "your family."
- **Decouple wealth from worth.** Cash never says "everyone can be rich." Cash says "you will be a clearer thinker about money no matter what you end up doing."
- **Name systemic factors honestly.** Wage gaps, geography, and luck shape outcomes. The skill we build is the skill in the student hands.
- **Protect the venture.** A student Capstone is theirs. We don't require they share revenue or family contribution. The artifact is the work, not the bank account.

Family engagement

Parents get one well-framed question per quarter — never a quiz, never a money-disclosure prompt. The default frame is curiosity ("What did you notice about your customers this week?"), not interrogation ("How much did you make?").

"Money is a tool. The question is not whether your family has a lot of it. The question is what you do with the moves we are practicing — interview, math, message, listen — wherever your starting line happens to be."

— CASH

ACTIVITY INDEX

Ten Activities. One Notebook.

Every activity in this book is built to be done with a pencil, your own evidence, and the questions Cash keeps asking. Skip nothing. Date everything. Re-read in three months.

No.	Activity	What you will do
01	Day 1 Customer Assumption	One sentence, one card. Don't try to be right; try to be specific.
02	Open vs. Leading Questions	Rewrite five leading questions into open ones. Practice on a partner.
03	Coding Patterns from Transcripts	Highlight surprises, frustrations, wishes. Tally them. Find the pattern.
04	Persona Pack v1	Combine evidence into one specific person — name, behaviors, top frustration.
05	Variable Cost per Unit	From a real receipt, compute the cost per one of the thing you sell.
06	Contribution Margin Worksheet	Price minus variable cost. Decide if it covers your fixed costs.
07	Two-Message A/B Test	Two honest messages. Three-day test. Report the winner and why.
08	Persuasion vs. Manipulation Line	Sort 10 ad claims onto a line. Defend your placement.
09	1-Week Feedback Loop	Collect, code, and act on feedback. Document three changes.
10	Final Capstone Defense	Five slides. Five minutes. Show the moves you made.

NOTEBOOK SETUP

Get a single notebook for the whole year. Number every page. The first 5 pages are your Vocabulary Spine. The last 5 pages are your Day-1 Assumptions (you will come back to those). Everything in between is your work.

Notebook checklist

- **Title page** — your name, your venture working-title, today's date.
- **Vocabulary spine** — 5 pages reserved for definitions you will add as we go.
-

Customer notes — one section for interview transcripts. Use direct quotes, with initials and dates.

- **Math section** — receipts taped in, per-unit computations, contribution margin scratch work.
- **Messaging section** — drafts of two-claim A/B tests, with what won and why.
- **Feedback log** — one page per week of your feedback system, with the three changes you made.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked Example: Per-Customer Math at the Snack Stand

Devon sells protein cookies after school. He sells 30 cookies a week at $2.00 each. Revenue is $60. He spends $0.85 on each cookie (oats, peanut butter, packaging). His variable cost per cookie is $0.85.

Contribution margin per cookie = $2.00 - $0.85 = **$1.15**. His fixed cost (the table he rents from the school store) is $20/week. He needs **$20 / $1.15 = 18 cookies/week** just to cover the table. He's currently selling 30. He's clearing $14.50/week after fixed costs.

Devon's question to Cash: should he raise the price to $2.50? Cash answers with a question: "Which people, and how do you know? Run a 3-day test. Half the kids see $2.00. Half see $2.50. Tell me what they actually buy."

WHAT TO COPY

The move here is not the answer. It is the structure: specific number, specific person, specific decision. Use that pattern in your own venture this quarter.

> *"Most adults skip this. You won't. Pick one customer. Compute one number. Decide one thing." — Cash*

END-OF-QUARTER REFLECTION

Four Quarters. Same Five Questions.

At the end of every quarter you will answer the same five questions. The answers should look different over time. Reread the previous quarter before you write a new one.

1. **Which people did you talk to this quarter, and what did they actually say?**

   Specific quotes, initials, dates. Resist the urge to summarize.
2. **What did you change in your venture because of evidence?**

   Name the change. Name the evidence that caused it.
3. **What is one number you know better now than three months ago?**

   Variable cost per unit. Contribution margin. Anything quantitative.
4. **What is a claim you made that you would take back?**

   Be honest. The claim does not have to be public. The honesty is the move.
5. **What would Cash ask you about all of this?**

   "Which people, and how do you know?" is always available. Find your own version.

> *"Reflection is not a feeling check-in. It is a memory tool. The you in three months wants to know what the you today learned. Write it down so future-you can use it."*
>
> — CASH

One promise.

Cash to Company makes one promise: students who move through this program will be clearer thinkers about money and entrepreneurship — no matter what they end up doing for a living.

We do not promise wealth. We do not promise success. We promise clarity.

"Customers are evidence, not assumptions."

— CASH, GRADE 7